Main Line Y Proposal for 2012 Summer Camp Financial Assistance Program

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Executive Overview:

The Main Line Y's 2012 Summer Camp Financial Assistance program provides an affordable childcare solution for working, low-income families by subsidizing up to 80% of their children's summer camp fees. Y camp offers a variety of character building activities for children and teens in a safe and nurturing environment. Knowing they can depend on the Y for consistent, quality childcare during the summer months brings peace of mind to many working parents, and helps preserve their job security. A grant in the amount of $5,000 will provide xx weeks of camp to children who otherwise would not be able to participate.

Like the Huston Foundation, the Y's core values stem from a long Christian heritage. All of our programs serve to strengthen children, families, and communities. We believe the 2012 Summer Camp Financial Assistance program aligns particularly well with Huston's overall mission and the Health and Human Services grants area on several levels:

- Affordable, dependable childcare promotes families' "self-reliance" by enabling a non-interrupted work schedule during the summer.
- Y camp programs are designed to nurture the "emotional and physical growth" of children and youth.
- Daily camp activities build confidence, responsibility, and leadership skills.
- This program ensures Y camp is accessible for all, regardless of income or circumstances.

1. Program Description:

The 2012 Summer Camp Financial Assistance program helps a particularly needy and often overlooked segment of underserved families in the main line area. Working, low-income, single parent families have few affordable, quality childcare options during the summer (private camps typically cost twice as much as Main Line Y camp). Y day camp provides an ideal solution to this short-term yet vital problem, and financial assistance makes it a reality by subsidizing up to 80% of camp fees for needy families.

Y summer camp runs from June 18th to August 24th and the hours are Monday through Friday from 8:30 - 4:00, with extended hours from 7:30 - 6:00 to accommodate working parents. The camp curriculum is designed to enrich each child through a variety of social, physical, and intellectual experiences. Typical daily activities (arts & crafts, sports, swimming, nature exploration, etc.) reinforce positive behaviors and social skills in a fun, stimulating, and safe environment. Field trips to local attractions and amusement parks add variety and excitement to the weekly schedule and are eagerly anticipated by campers. Through it all campers have fun and make friends; but more importantly they improve their confidence and social skills, while steadily becoming more responsible and independent.

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The atmosphere at camp is always upbeat and Y counselors are dedicated and well qualified. Average attendance is about 130 campers per week and the support staff consists of 25 employees. Y counselors are over age 18 and most are college students who return seasonally, (some are former Y campers themselves!). The program director is a former Y counselor with 8 years of experience, and is pursuing a degree in therapeutic recreation which adds a unique level of insight to camp activities. All staff undergo background checks and annually receive a minimum of 40 hours of pre-camp training including First Aid, CPR, and safety procedures.

Although we are located in Ardmore, we are committed to serving families in need throughout the region, and central to our mission is a commitment to "never turn anyone away from the Y because of inability to pay." Numerous families have come to depend on the Summer Camp Financial Assistance program for quality childcare and to preserve their job security during the summer. The Main Line Y branch is solely responsible for funding 100% of these program costs, and each season additional fundraising is needed to ensure that Y camp remains accessible to those who need it most. There is no deadline for financial assistance applications and families typically apply throughout season. However as summer progresses and funds deplete, we cannot consistently maintain the levels of subsidies needed.

2. Statement of Need:

Statistics to support the community need for Summer Camp Financial Assistance are based on data collected from program applicants. Eligibility is determined in accordance with federal poverty level guidelines, and subsidy amounts granted per family (25% - 80% of weekly camp fees) are calculated based on financial need, available funds, and total number of subsidy requests.

In 2011 we provided approximately $xx,000 in financial assistance to xx families which subsidized camp fees for xxx campers. The majority of these subsidies were provided to single parent, working families. While we were proud of that accomplishment we were still unable to meet the overall demand, and over xx weeks of camp remained underfunded. We expect the needs to increase approximately 13% for the 2012 season; therefore we anticipate xxx campers will require $xx,000 in camp subsidies.

3. Program Goals:

The general goal of the 2012 Summer Camp Financial Assistance program is to subsidize Main Line Y camp fees for 100% of families who meet the application criteria. Specifically, we expect to subsidize a total of xxx weeks of camp, by covering 25% - 80% of the weekly fees. Approximately xxx campers are expected to benefit from reduced camp fees through this program.

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On a broader scale, this program ensures Y camp is accessible to all children in the greater Ardmore community, regardless of family income or circumstances. The outcome for families is the assurance of a dependable, quality childcare option for the summer workdays. The outcome for campers is a fun and enriching experience; but more importantly they develop self-esteem and interpersonal skills in a safe, nurturing environment.

4. Organization Mission and Information:

The Main Line Y is located in Ardmore, PA and is a branch of the YMCA of Philadelphia & Vicinity. We share in the Y's overall mission: *To translate the principles of the YMCA's Christian heritage into programs that nurture children, strengthen families, build strong communities, and develop healthy spirits, minds, and bodies for all.*

The Main Line Y's programs embody the core values of Caring, Honesty, Respect, and Responsibility and focus on the following areas:

- Youth Development - Through the Y, children cultivate values, skills, and relationships that lead to positive behaviors, better health, and educational achievement.
- Healthy Living - We bring families closer together and encourage healthy lifestyles through fitness, sports, fun, and shared interests.
- Social Responsibility - We foster the care and respect all people need and deserve through volunteerism and community support activities

We are an equal opportunity service provider and ensure access to all by providing financial assistance to anyone who cannot afford the membership or program fees. The Main Line Y branch is solely responsible for funding 100% of the costs for Summer Camp Financial Assistance subsidies.

5. Evaluation Process:

<u>Quantitative Evaluation Process:</u> All financial assistance data (family information, subsidies requested, eligibility status, and subsidies granted) is tracked in a spreadsheet. Careful management of this process enables us to maintain a level of financial assistance throughout the summer. Additionally, the data is used to track subsidy histories and measure the overall success rate of the program each season. Our success criteria are to provide 100% of eligible families with the full subsidy amount they qualify for.

<u>Qualitative Evaluation Process:</u> Feedback on families' satisfaction levels with Y summer camp is continually collected throughout the season via parent satisfaction surveys and one-on-one camp counselor/parent meetings. Parent communication regarding camp activities is further supplemented with a newsletter distributed in both email and hardcopy formats. All feedback is evaluated to identify areas for Y camp program improvements.

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6. Sustainability:

Financial assistance has always been essential to maintaining the Y's commitment "to never turn anyone away because of inability to pay." Summer Camp Financial Assistance arose from a short-term yet vital need for extra financial support for single parent families during the summer workdays. We have been subsidizing camp fees for over 30 years, and subsidized Y camp has become an integral part of the summer routine for many local families.

Summer Camp Financial Assistance is included in the Main Line Y's annual budget and 100% of funds are raised through donations. Due to the longstanding nature of this program, administrative procedures for evaluating applications and calculating subsidies are both accurate and efficient. Effective communications between Y staff and parents have been established and are continually updated to accommodate new technologies such as email and cell phones. All data (family information, subsidies requested, eligibility status, and subsidies granted) is tracked in a spreadsheet. Careful management of this process enables us to maintain a level of financial assistance throughout the summer.

7. Budget Summary:

The Main Line Y branch is solely responsible for raising 100% of the funds for the Summer Camp Financial Assistance program. See appendix for additional budget detail.

Total Anticipated 2012 Camp Financial Assistance Requirements:	$xx,000
Donations from Y Board, Staff, and Members:	$xx,000
Donations from Community Supporters and Local Businesses:	$xx,000
Huston Foundation Human Services Grant:	$ x,000
Other Grant Revenue:	$ x,000
Fundraising Events Revenue:	$ x,000

8. Conclusion:

The 2012 Summer Camp Financial Assistance program helps a particularly needy and often overlooked segment of underserved families in the main line vicinity. For three decades, the Main Line Y has been proud to provide a quality, dependable, summertime childcare solution for financially disadvantaged families. This program exemplifies the Y's dedication to youth development, social responsibility, and equal access for all regardless of income or circumstances.

We believe the program benefits are well matched with the Huston Foundation's focus on promoting families' "self-reliance," and fostering the "emotional and physical growth" of children and youth. A grant in the amount of $5,000 will help to ensure this longstanding program can continue in 2012.

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